



VIGILANT: Pedigreed dogs getting anti-terrorist training

HK RAJASHEKAR

CANINE SOLDIERS

With terrorists increasingly using explosives to target public places, there is a surge in the demand for sniffer dogs to use their unique senses for detection but they need proper training

■ **By Ramesh Vinayak**

It's time for the evening drill at the Maharaja Ranjit Singh Punjab Police Academy (PPA) at Phillaur. But even before the cops under training line up in the grounds, one corner resonates with commands like 'stand-up' and 'salute', the tone and tenor that of a parade commander. However, the name prefixed with each shout is a giveaway—Rano, Raja, Steffy, Sunny, Kelvin, Bully and Tango. They are among the current batch of 31 pedigree police dogs in Punjab and Haryana, honing their explosive and narcotic detection skills. Set up in 2000, the dog breeding-cum-training centre at PPA has never had such a busy schedule. Next month, it will receive another batch of 25 trainees from the

Uttar Pradesh Police, which plans to acquire 150 sniffer dogs.

With terror outfits increasingly employing explosives to target public places, there has been an unprecedented surge in the demand for canine detectives among the state police and paramilitary forces. The mounting pressure of VIP protection in the face of the threat of hard-to-detect RDX and plastic explosives has forced security agencies to draft sniffer dogs into sanitise-and-secure operations.

In fact, at an internal security review meeting last month, the Union Home Ministry advised state police forces to raise dog squads as part of the Centre-funded modernisation plan. States afflicted with Naxalite-violence have been specifically asked to draft more sniffer dogs to counter the men-

ace of improvised explosive devices used by Maoist insurgents. Already, the Central Reserve Police Force has drawn up plans to raise a 600-strong dog squad while the Indo-Tibetan Border Police and the Central Industrial Security Force have recently set up in-house dog training facilities.

Besides Phillaur, there are only three major dog training centres in the country, run by the Army in Meerut, Border Security Force (BSF) in Tekanpur and the Andhra Pradesh Police. "There is a big demand-supply gap for sniffer dogs," says Suman Kumar Sharma, adjutant and master dog trainer, who helped set up a dog training centre in Ethiopia, in 2004. In the last six years, PPA—the second largest dog training centre after Andhra Pradesh—has trained 260